Lunenburg Annual Town Reports, 1959–2010

What a complete, page-by-page reading of the financial tables found · The Lunenburg Budget Project · 30 October 2026

52
annual town reports, 1959–2010, added to the fifteen fiscal-year reports (FY2011–FY2025) already held

1,818
pages holding financial tables in the 1959–2010 reports, every one read

1,647
of those pages reconcile to a total printed on the page itself

Summary

Lunenburg has published an annual town report every year since at least 1959. Together the reports are a continuous record of the town's finances, government and schools across more than six decades. We are grateful to the town officers, boards and committees who wrote and printed them.

We digitized every financial table in the 1959–2010 reports and checked each page against the totals the page itself prints. Of 1,818 such pages, 1,647 reconcile. The remaining 171 are recorded individually, each with the reason it cannot be confirmed and the document that would resolve it:

- **About 105 pages** print a total that does not equal the sum of its own lines.
- **17 pages** are scanned too poorly to settle a digit.
- **49 pages** hold no checkable total. These are salary schedules, fee lists, charts and comparisons.

Nothing in this review suggests that funds are unaccounted for. A printed total that disagrees with its lines is, on its face, a typing or printing discrepancy. The town's ledgers for that year would settle it.

1. Printed totals that do not reconcile

These are discrepancies in the reports as printed, confirmed against an image of each page. The most significant:

REPORT	AS PRINTED	WHAT THE PAGE'S OWN FIGURES REQUIRE
1998, p. 62	Outstanding debt total $2,875,830	$3,535,830; one $660,000 issue is not carried into the total
1965, p. 44	Bonded debt, grand total principal $168,200	$1,682,000 (apparently a dropped digit)
1990, p. 22	Receipts grand total $8,174,269.84	The 125 receipt lines sum to $7,193,802.84
2005, p. 85	FY2006 omnibus budget total $22,368,960	$22,341,960, both the sum of the categories and the amount voted under Article 3

2007, p. 55	Assessors' class valuation total $1,285,947,900	The class lines sum to $1,285,915,200
1967, pp. 71–72	Voted budget total $1,612,336.00	The 81 budget lines sum to $1,621,336.00
1975, p. 76	A schedule row printing 117,316.71	177,316.71, by both identities the row belongs to

Many of the smaller discrepancies are exactly $10, $100, $200 or $1,000, or are a pair of transposed digits. That is consistent with figures keyed by hand, though this review cannot establish the cause.

2. Reports with missing, incomplete or out-of-order pages

These concern the PDF copies the town publishes, which are scans of the printed reports.

REPORT	ISSUE	EFFECT
1999	Printed pages 105–106 are absent from the PDF, mid-way through the school department's wage list	The names held sum to $6,018,558.34 against the printed total of $8,198,325.62; roughly $2.18 million of the list is not in the file
1997	The town employees' wage list ends part-way through the alphabet, and the next two pages are blank scans	No town total is printed, so the missing portion cannot be measured. The school list is complete.
1992	The index lists 13 pages the file does not contain	The most incomplete edition in the set
2000	The index refers to pages beyond the end of the file	A small number of indexed pages are absent
Nine other editions	One or two indexed pages absent	None affects a financial table identified in this review
1994, pp. 42–43	Figures printed incomplete (for example "$9.50")	The page cannot be reconciled

Scans too poor to read with certainty (17 pages): 1980, 1985, 1990, 1993, 1995, 1998, 2000, 2004, 2006, 2007 and 2010. The 2010 report is the weakest scan, with seven affected pages.

No school staff roster printed: 1976, 1986, 1987 and 1994. The rosters for 1988–1999 are partial.

Minor structural issues appear in about twenty editions: duplicated page numbers, pages bound out of order, and warrant article numbers that skip. These make the reports harder to navigate but do not remove content.

3. How the reading was checked

Tables were digitized with Amazon Textract and then tested against the arithmetic each page prints: columns that should sum to a total, and balances that should equal available funds less spending.

- **Misread figures.** Where a figure appeared to be misread, an independent second reading of the page image was taken. A correction was accepted only when it matched exactly and a printed total depended on it.
  - 99 figures were corrected this way.
  - Every correction records the figure as printed.
- **Our own errors found and fixed in the process:**
  - one page that had passed for the wrong reason;
  - six second readings withdrawn on audit;
  - a footnote ("Includes Escrow") that changes how one 1985 total is read.

4. Points to keep in mind when using these figures

- **"Reconciles" describes a page, not every row on it.** A page counts as reconciled when at least one of its tables closes on a printed total. Individual rows carry their own check status.
- **Rounding.** Differences of under $1 are treated as rounding and are labelled as such wherever they occur.
- **Calendar years, not fiscal years.** The 1959–2010 reports are calendar-year editions; 1973–74 covers an 18-month transition. Figures should not be compared directly with the fiscal-year reports from FY2011.
- **Tax rates compare only within one assessment.** Revaluations in 1970, 1982 and 1989 break the series. The 1969 rate of $133.00 per $1,000 and the 1970 rate of $33.00 describe different valuations.
- **Staff rosters are lists of names.** They give no hours, funding source or start date. A name appearing across years is not proof of one continuous career.
- **Population figures** sometimes differ between editions for the same census year. For 1980, one edition prints 8,375 and a later one prints 8,710. Both are recorded.

5. Where to find it

The reports, the digitized tables and a summary of highlights are published at **lunenburgbudgetproject.org**. See */analysis/historical-report* and */analysis/annual-reports*. Every figure cited links to its report and page. Each source PDF is provided with a checksum, so it can be confirmed identical to the town's copy.

Prepared by the Lunenburg Budget Project from the Town of Lunenburg's published annual town reports. Counts are as of 30 October 2026. This is a review of the published documents, not an audit of the town's accounts.